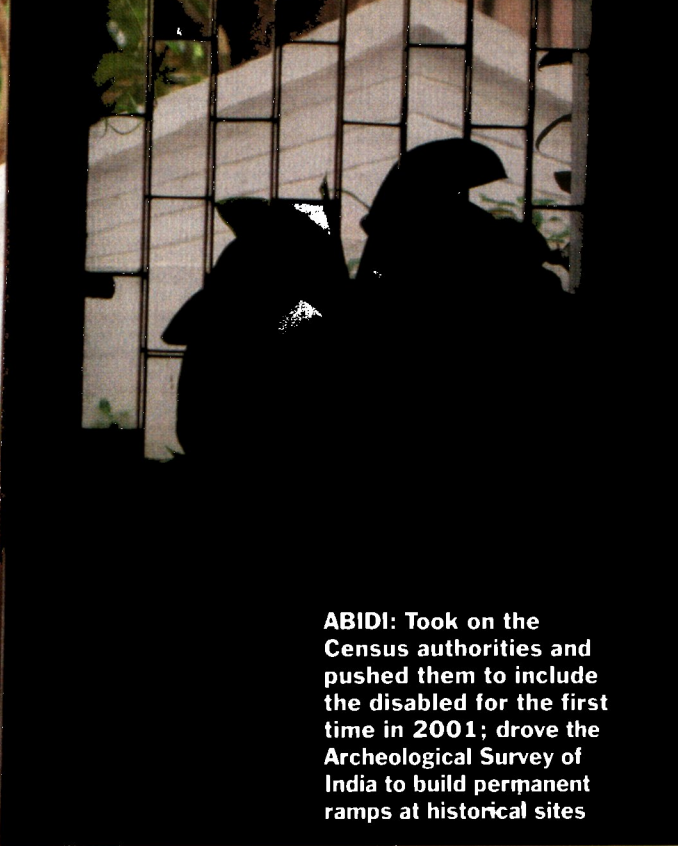




ABIDI: Took on the Census authorities and pushed them to include the disabled for the first time in 2001; drove the Archeological Survey of India to build permanent ramps at historical sites

89% Indians with special needs have physical disability while 11 per cent are mentally disabled.

don't have any official guidelines on proper gradient, flooring, lighting, design, symbols and signage that make a place accessible." It was this exasperation that led her to set up AccessAbility, a firm that specialises in barrier-free design and employment solutions for the disabled.

Doors started closing when Mohit was just six. Right after his first spinal operation, his school told his parents to remove him ("All classes are held upstairs"). His parents ran around until they came across a school run by the Spastics Society. It flatly refused: "He is brain-normal and we only admit children with cerebral palsy." The parents begged and pleaded, the school relented and Mohit started studying with mentally-slow students. After Class VIII, he was shifted out to another school. "I couldn't attend the computer science practicals that were held upstairs," rues Mohit. "I just learnt the theory bit."

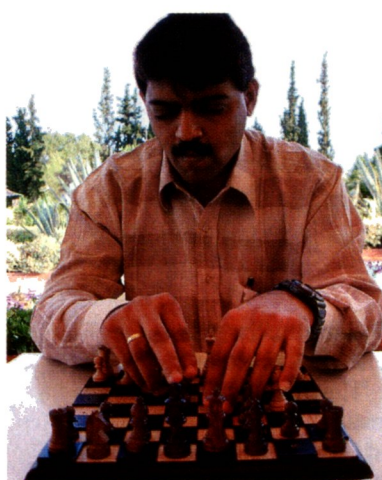
"If you let us know the name of the institute where Mohit wants to do his animation course, we can persuade them to provide wheelchair access," wrote T.D. Dhariyal, the deputy commissioner for persons with disability, to Mohit's parents. But the humane face of public service can

hardly compensate for the loopholes in the law. The Persons with Disabilities Act of 1995 makes it mandatory for all government and aided institutions to be disabled-friendly, but excludes the private sector. "Without bringing the private sector under the ambit of the law, changes may not be effective," says Dhariyal.

Mohit creates his world within the four walls. He tutors his brother, plays carom or computer games with his friends, gets into scraps with his parents (say, over the length of his hair or over latest objects of desire—a Nokia N73 mobile, now). "I can't go out," he points out. "Where will I go? Even the roads are bumpy." That's what Anjee Agarwal is lobbying for. Ever since a muscular dystrophy confined her to a wheelchair, the accessibility consultant and her team

at Samarthyam have been trying to make public space and transport barrier-free. Turning the upmarket tourist spot of Dilli Haat disabled-friendly was their pilot project. They worked with Delhi Metro, toiled with MCDelhi to make the pavements on Delhi's Bus Rapid Transit corridor wider and tactile, laboured with the Delhi Transport Corporation to introduce disabled-friendly buses now plying in the capital.

Dignity is the other issue Mohit is learning to grapple with. One of the animation institutes offered to pick him up bodily and carry down the stairs to the classroom every day. His parents found the idea too undignified. "But in a country where no one has you on their



JADHAV: Visually-impaired international chess champion, working to provide jobs for the blind in the software sector